

anced in our lives, including giving and saving. Since giving pays eternal dividends and savings pay only interest, when in doubt, lean more toward giving. But God can accomplish both when you're seeking to apply His principles. As the Apostle Paul wrote, "And God is able to make all grace abound to you, that always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed" (2 Corinthians 9:8). Since God's Word discusses investing, inheritance, and savings, it is clear that not all surpluses are to be given away. Some are to be retained and multiplied for future needs. That's why long-term plans are so necessary. As you read through the chapters on insurance, inheritance, and retirement, you need to begin formulating your own goals.

16 INSURANCE

Two questions are often asked regarding insurance: "Is insurance scriptural, and does owning insurance reflect a lack of faith?" The answers are both yes and no. Insurance is not specifically defined in Scripture; however, the principle of future provision is. Owning insurance does not necessarily reflect a lack of faith (trust) in God, though it can. However, just as damaging are the secondary effects that insurance is having on our society: those of greed, slothfulness, waste, and fear.

Americans have developed an insurance ethic that often rationalizes cheating where insurance companies are concerned. Many committed Christians are willing to use insurance funds to do things they would never consider doing with their own money. Recently, a Christian physician and I were discussing the issue when he related an all too common event. A Christian patient of his was in need of diagnostic tests. The doctor suggested that she receive the tests as a hospital outpatient because the costs would be substantially less. "Oh no," she said, "my insurance only pays if I'm admitted to a hospital for at least two days, and I want the best." Certainly, this Christian lady would never consider willfully cheating somebody—